

Attempts to trace the history of the railways would be impossible without unearthing its historically structured links with the Anglo-Indian community. They are deeply and inextricably linked. In 1905, the Anglo-Indian community was less than half a per cent of India's population, but made up 2 per cent of the total workforce in the railways. As such, the community serves as a living archive of the social history of the railways in India.

Employed by the railways

From when the first tracks were laid in India, the ranks of the railways were suffused with domiciled Europeans and Eurasians. The colonial state preferentially recruited them to responsible positions, pushing the natives to the lowest levels of the hierarchy. "It will take time to qualify them for the more arduous duties of locomotive drivers, which require coolness, courage, and decision ..." wrote Juland Danvers, the Government director of the railways in India, in 1877. Indians were thus considered suitable only for working in subordinate menial positions, fixing rail lines, or repairing equipment in loco sheds, all under the watchful eyes of their white superiors.

By 1870, rising costs of European recruitment forced the railways to open up all posts to Indians. There was minimal change, however, with Indians occupying a mere 47 of the 800-odd upper administrative posts. The security of railway operations led to the collation of an Anglo-Indian workforce. Nurtured as natural corollaries of the civilized white man, they were viewed as the ideal employees. They cost less than Europeans, their material culture was decidedly Western, viewed as more loyal owing to their genealogy, and being born in the Indian subcontinent, hardy and acclimatized.

As a result, between 1870 and 1905, almost 50 per cent of all Anglo-Indians were dependent on the railways for their economic sustenance and employed as guards, drivers, firemen, loco-foremen, and line maintenance staff.

A home of their own

The hierarchy displayed in the hiring policies of the railways made its way into the institution's social life. Railway colonies were designed,